

Forestry Graduate Student Organization Constitution

December 12, 2013; Amended March 27, 2016, January 16, 2024, and October 13, 2025

1. Statement of Purpose

The purpose of the Forestry Graduate Student Organization (FGSO) is as follows:

1. To educate the Michigan State University (MSU) community and the broader public on the field of forestry and forest science-related issues via organization of seminars and public events;
2. To serve as a voice of the graduate student body within the Department of Forestry by providing a safe and confidential forum for students to raise concerns about ongoing department activity. As well, to act as a liaison between graduate students and faculty regarding shared student body values and concerns.
 - see also ‘Graduate Student Committee,’ composed of Forestry Department faculty and the graduate student committee representatives.
3. Plan and fund (in part) intra- and inter-departmental social events as part of a larger effort to support and contribute to a strong and active graduate student community;
4. Act as the intermediary between the Department of Forestry, the Council of Graduate Students (COGS), and the Michigan State University administration.

2. Membership

The FGSO is open to any member of the MSU student body (undergraduate or graduate). The organization is focused primarily on graduate activity within the Department of Forestry, but we are open to and appreciate the ideas and opinions of all MSU community members. Membership status will be recorded and maintained by the FGSO communications manager (see 3.1b). In particular, the organization will not discriminate on the basis of age, color, gender, gender identity, disability status, height, marital status, national origin, political persuasion, race, religion, sexual orientation, veteran status, or weight. While we welcome participation from all MSU community members, only MSU students may be officers and/or voting members (per University rules and regulations). Voting members are defined as undergraduate & graduate students that are affiliated with the Department of Forestry at MSU.

2.1 Membership Status, Discipline, and Removal

The FGSO supports an open, respectful community consistent with MSU policies and the FGSO Statement of Purpose. Grounds for disciplinary action include sustained disruption of FGSO activities, harassment, misuse of FGSO resources, or conduct that violates MSU policies or law.

Actions may include a written warning, temporary loss of privileges, or removal from membership.

Process

- a) **Initiation:** Any voting member may submit a written concern to the President and/or Secretary. The submission should describe the conduct at issue and prior informal steps, if any.
- b) **Notice:** The Secretary will provide written notice of the concern to the member at least **10 calendar days** before the meeting at which the matter will be considered. Notice includes the alleged conduct, proposed action, and meeting details.
- c) **Meeting:** The item will appear on the agenda of a regular or special meeting. The member may offer a brief statement and respond to questions.
- d) **Decision:** Removal from membership requires a **one-half vote of voting members present**.
- e) **Appeal:** Within 7 days, the member may submit a written appeal to the President. An appeal will be placed on the next agenda and decided by a **simple majority**.
- f) **Records:** The Secretary will retain the notice, decision, and outcome with meeting minutes.

All actions will be consistent with MSU policies, including the Anti-Discrimination Policy.

3. Officers

The FGSO is intended to create a rich and open community, inclusive of all forestry graduate students. The purpose of officers is to encourage membership, ensure organization function, facilitate discussion, plan activities, & communicate decisions amongst all members.

Importantly, the FGSO is horizontally structured so all members have a voice of equal value. As such, officers do not have additional voting rights or greater influence on decisions than other members of the FGSO that do not hold positions within the organization.

In most circumstances, one individual will hold one position; if necessary, any person may hold two positions, excluding the position of the FGSO President and the Graduate Symposium Chair. Two separate individuals must hold those two positions. Figure 1 depicts the positional relationships of the FGSO.

3.1 Positions and Responsibilities

- a) **President:** Leads general FGSO proceedings. Responsibilities include registering the organization through student life, organizing and running monthly meetings, assisting other officers in various duties, and ensuring that FGSO activities and operations are

consistent with the Statement of Purpose and regulations herein. Makes efforts to coordinate and assist other members/officer positions as needed to meet responsibilities. Records new membership and maintains a list of voting members and email addresses of those members.

- b) **Secretary:** Responsible for communicating meeting times, dates, and locations one to two weeks in advance to members, communicating discussions and decisions from meeting within one week of meeting to all members. Will also take notes during meetings and distribute them after meetings. Records new membership and maintains a list of voting members and email addresses of those members.
- c) **Communications/Outreach Manager:** Manages email account and addresses within that account; may have the account re-addressed to a personal email address for convenience, but will end that connection upon change of position. At the officer's discretion, can coordinate/publish outreach through social media channels or otherwise, but must have a contingency plan established in shared FGSO resources for Forestry Graduate Student online presence. Coordinate with the Forestry Departmental communications team on publishing content and conducting outreach when necessary.
- d) **Activities/Social Planning Chair:** Leads planning efforts including professional, academic, and social events. The holder of this position should seek to initiate a variety of events, but can change from year to year. Ideas include: a welcome event in the fall semester, holiday party, spring picnic, tours of relevant centers on the MSU campus (Library, Statistics, etc.), trips to MSU research stations (W.K. Kellogg Experimental Forest, Tree Research Center, etc.), inviting guest speakers, organizing an oral/poster presentation workshop in the fall, identifying campus-related academic or professional events of interest to members (through PhD Career Services in the MSU Graduate School, Graduate Student Life through the MSU Graduate School, etc.). Responsibilities include recruiting co-chairs/other members willing to help with events, surveying members for their preferences, determining event costs, identifying venues, and setting up events. The holder of this position should plan and/or identify at least one event per month, as simple as a Friday evening social gathering, a walk in a park, exploring the Maker's Space in the MSU Main Library, or any event that may interest a portion of the membership. This position lends itself well to co-chairs.
- e) **Treasurer & Fundraising Manager:** Manages FGSO funds. Responsibilities include tracking FGSO accounts and keeping FGSO officers/members informed of finances. Potential funding sources include the College of Agriculture and Natural Resources, the Jane E Wonders Fund, COGS, the MSU Graduate School, the Forestry Department, and other non-academic forestry-related organizations.
- f) **COGS Representative:** Serves as liaison between the FGSO and COGS. Responsibilities include attending monthly COGS meetings, participating in their activities, and reporting back to FGSO members and the larger Forestry graduate student

body.

- g) **Graduate Student Committee Representative:** Serves alongside Forestry Department faculty in the Graduate Student Committee, reviews and collaborates on work about the graduate student departmental affairs. Represents interests and concerns on behalf of students and the FGSO within the Graduate Student Committee. Informs the FGSO of ongoing matters discussed in the Graduate Student Committee.
- h) **Graduate Symposium Chair:** Chairs the annual graduate research symposium planning committee, serves as liaison between symposium planning committee and FGSO. Responsibilities include soliciting participants from the fall semester of FOR 802 and overseeing the graduate student symposium. The Graduate Symposium Chair is encouraged to follow the guide in section 4.3, Graduate Research Symposium Committee.
- i) **Sustainability Council Representative:** Serves on the Sustainability Council and acts as a liaison to external environmental organizations. Keeps the FGSO informed about sustainability initiatives and events on campus. Reviews and contributes to sustainability-focused departmental affairs alongside faculty and stakeholders.
- j) **DEI Committee Representative:** Serves alongside the Forestry Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion Committee (DEI) and ensures the department's compliance with MSU's core values of quality, inclusiveness, and connectivity. Responsibilities include attending bi-yearly meetings and whenever needed to understand and address pressing departmental DEI matters. Ideally two student members serve this position at one time.

3.2 Elections & Term Limits

Elections for all positions will be held once a year at the end of the Spring semester. The vote will be conducted by all voting members of FGSO, as well as all forestry graduate students. Newly elected officers take positions in the following fall term and serve for one academic year (e.g., Fall '13 - Spring '14). Any current voting member of FGSO may run for an open position. No nomination is required. Officers are restricted to two consecutive terms in any one position but may serve in a different position after consecutive terms. A special election will be held if an elected officer completes their degree or is no longer a current MSU student.

3.3 Termination of Position

Officers may be voted out of a position if they are not meeting their duties including: attending FGSO meetings, actively participating in events, and meeting the specific responsibilities of their position (as described in Section 3.1). If the president fails in that position's duties, any other FGSO member may schedule an FGSO meeting to remedy the failure. Only voting members of the FGSO may vote to remove an officer from their position, and only votes from members present at a meeting will count in this decision. Attendance will include those voting members

who attend both in person and virtually. A virtual option must be available to voting members. The officer must be given at least one month's notice prior to a removal vote to provide an opportunity for improved performance. The loss of current MSU student status will immediately terminate any currently held position within FGSO.

A vote for Impeachment will occur if any person currently holding an FGSO position is found to exhibit any behavior that is not in line with the FGSO's or the Forestry Department's current membership values/community norms. This includes any discovered form of discrimination. The call to vote for impeachment will occur in a timely fashion after the discovery of the offense, after an opportunity has been given for a short verbal self-defense (no longer than 5 minutes). Impeachment requires a simple majority vote. Officer removal decisions will be recorded in the minutes and filed consistent with Section 5.

4. Operating Procedures

4.1 Meetings

The FGSO will meet once per month to discuss ongoing proceedings and future events. The meetings will be open to any interested member of the MSU community and run as an open forum, chaired and facilitated by the president and/or other officers since their committed presence at the meetings presumes continuity in discussions. Additional meetings may be scheduled as necessary. The FGSO reserves the right to exclude any current MSU faculty or administrative staff member from scheduled meetings if it is decided that their presence compromises the confidentiality of FGSO meetings and would prohibit the goals of the FGSO from being achieved (as described in the Statement of Purpose). Officers must commit to attending all meetings, and all members should strive to attend. Meeting times may vary from semester to semester, but should be consistent within semesters to facilitate regularity and attendance. Quorum is met when at least **25 percent of voting members or 4 voting members**, whichever is greater, are present in person or virtually. Suggested meeting times and locations include the lunch hour in the collaboration room, or after regular working hours at some predetermined on- or off-campus location.

4.2 Use of Funds

Some FGSO funds may be used to fund member participation in events, provided that those participating in the event agree to share the information and/or report back to the FGSO. This may be especially useful when an activity is of interest to members, but not all members are available to attend. These funds may also support a group of members in a team-building activity of any kind.

4.3 Graduate Research Symposium Committee

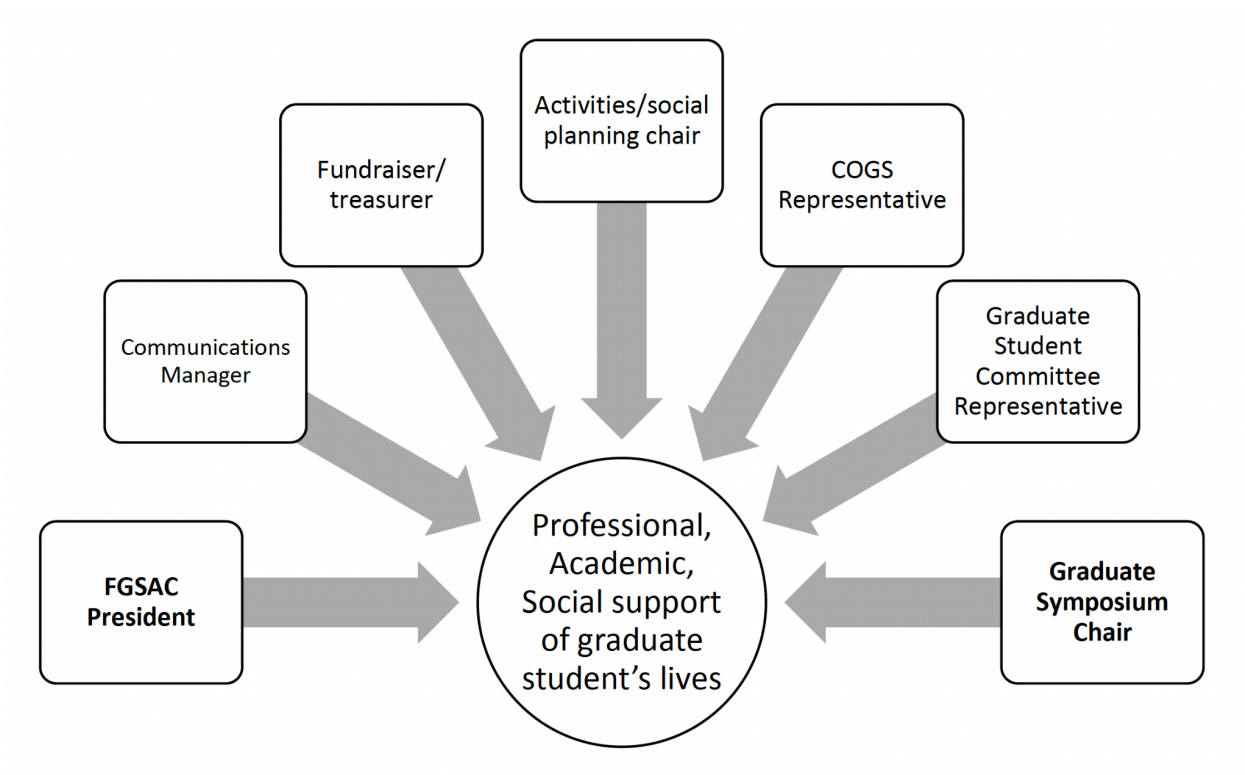
The graduate student research symposium planning committee is responsible for all aspects of the annual graduate student research symposium. This day-long event is held the second Thursday of February. Chittenden Hall is a convenient and symbolic location because the MSU Graduate School has not charged for its use, and it is the former Forestry Department building. Over the past four years, we have had about 50 people attend the symposium throughout the day. Below is a guide to graduate symposium planning, along with Figure 2. These comments are meant as suggestions for the event overall. The graduate symposium planning chair should initiate the first two listed points:

- When the fall semester begins, introduce the event to the incoming graduate cohort in FOR 802 and/or the first FGSO fall semester meeting to recruit their involvement on the committee. Plan to hold the first organizing meeting in September and have a call for abstracts out by November. This facilitates creating a schedule and program that can be distributed mid- to late-January.
- At the first meeting, organize duties and responsibilities for the team. A maximum of two people is ideal per position:
 - Graduate symposium planning committee chair/co-chairs:
 - Organize meetings
 - Serve as ‘face’ of the committee - report back to FGSO and department, sending all team member’s communications through this position
 - Is otherwise not part of a sub-team, but fills in when and where necessary
 - Prepares a welcome table for symposium, especially name tags and giveaways (door prizes, etc).
 - Gives opening address
 - Contact symposium presenter award winners
 - Conduct post-symposium meeting
 - Keynote invitation and logistics
 - Identify 3-5 potential keynote speakers, draft invitations (included in file)
 - Once confirmed, request completion of W-9 form for honorarium.
 - Mail parking passes one week in advance.
 - Introduce keynote
 - Cross-check with the Hanover seminar series to not double-invite speakers
 - Recruit faculty and postdoc participants as judges. One idea is to request 5 minutes during a faculty meeting, describing the event, thanking previous judges by name, and sending a sign-up sheet around. We need three judges per presenter, and each judge should have 3-4 presenters total to judge. (Some background information should be solicited in which faculty provide the most

useful feedback.)

- Fund-raising
 - Identify potential sponsors, draft letters requesting funds, maintain a living document recording amounts requested from whom, and expected itemized costs of the symposium.
 - Ensure sponsors and donors are appropriately represented in the program; this requires collaboration with the communications team.
- Communications and promotions
 - Creates and promotes events, beginning in the fall semester. This especially targets graduate student involvement as presenters AND as audience members. Both are critical to a successful event. One idea is to attend each faculty member's lab meeting, or to request FGSO members who are part of various faculty labs to communicate and emphasize participation in the symposium. Posters one week prior campus-wide; posters day of with donors and sponsors.
 - Write invitations and notices of symposium department-wide, college-wide, to sponsors and donors, and to relevant Forestry groups on- and off-campus, including undergraduate Forestry students and the Michigan DNR; send through Grad symposium chair/s.
 - Collects RSVPs for the event: attendees and presenters
 - Collects abstracts
 - Creates schedule and program, ensures digital presence on MSU Forestry homepage or elsewhere
- Location and food logistics
 - Schedule and reserve space for the graduate symposium for the 2nd Thursday in February; we strongly suggest Chittenden Hall as the event space.
 - Identify food, coordinate delivery - collaborate with communications team for headcount
 - Identify moderator/s
 - Identify photographer/s
 - Identify filmer/s to record each presenter for their opportunity to watch themselves present (simple purpose of improving).
 - Reserve and bring departmental computers and cameras
 - Load presentations day preceding the symposium
- All planning committee members should be prepared to dedicate their day to the symposium, and help set up and clean up at the beginning and end of the day.
- Some members should stay at the welcome table at the symposium's opening to greet attendees, help with name tags, hand out programs, and otherwise

coordinate the beginning of the day.



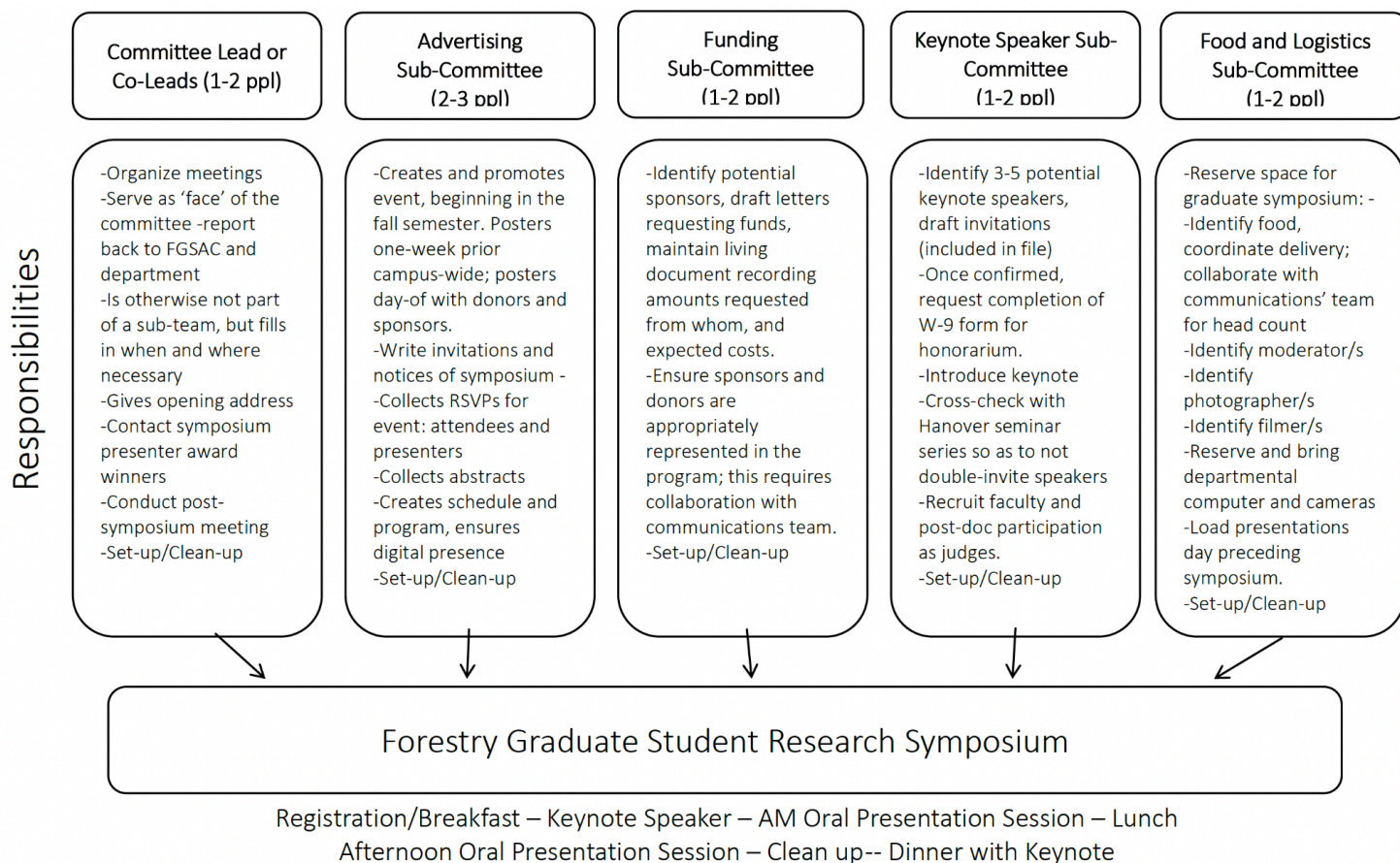


Figure 1. Forestry Graduate Student Organization Legislative Chart. **Figure 2.** Forestry Graduate Research Symposium organizational chart.

5. Amendments

Amendments ensure this constitution remains clear and useful to members.

Process

- a) **Proposal:** Any voting member may propose an amendment by submitting the text to the Secretary.
- b) **Notice:** Proposed amendments must be distributed to all voting members at least **14 calendar days** prior to the vote.
- c) **Review:** The proposal will be discussed at a scheduled meeting. Friendly edits may be accepted by consent of the proposer.
- d) **Approval:** Amendments require a **two-thirds vote of voting members present**.
- e) **Filing:** Upon approval, the Secretary will update the governing document on file and submit the revised constitution to the appropriate MSU office per RSO procedures. The amendment takes effect upon passage unless a later date is specified.

6. Dissolution

The FGSO may dissolve if its mission can no longer be advanced by the membership.

Process

- a) **Initiation:** A dissolution motion may be introduced by the President or by a petition signed by one-third of voting members of record.
- b) **Notice:** The Secretary will circulate the motion and a brief rationale to all voting members at least 21 calendar days before the vote.
- c) **Approval:** Dissolution requires a one-half vote of voting members present at a regular or special meeting.
- d) **Assets and Records:** After satisfying lawful obligations, all remaining FGSO funds and property will be transferred to an MSU account designated for the benefit of Forestry graduate students, such as a departmental gift account, consistent with MSU RSO requirements. The Treasurer and President will coordinate final reporting and account closure with the University.
- e) **Notification:** The Secretary will notify the appropriate MSU office and file the required end-of-year or dissolution documentation.